

Liberia



Area 43,000 sq miles
(111,370 sq km)
Population 4.1 million
Capital Monrovia
Currency Liberian dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 45 years



Liberia lies in West Africa. It was founded in 1847 by freed American slaves. Liberia faced civil wars from the 1990s, until peace was declared in 2003. In 2006, Liberia's president, Ellen Johnson Sirleaf, became Africa's first female elected head of state.

Ivory Coast



Area 124,502 sq miles
(322,460 sq km)
Population 20.2 million
Capital Yamoussoukro
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 48 years



Ivory Coast—officially Côte d'Ivoire—was a French colony until 1960. Once a politically stable country, it slipped into internal chaos following an army coup in 1999. Civil erupted in 2002, and much of the north is still under the control of rebel groups. Ivory Coast is the world's biggest producer of cocoa.

Algeria



Area 919,595 sq miles
(2,381,740 sq km)
Population 36 million
Capital Algiers
Currency Algerian dinar
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 72 years



Extending from a densely populated Mediterranean coast to the uninhabited northern Sahara is Africa's largest country, Algeria. It won independence from France in 1962. Algerians are predominantly Arabs who follow the Sunni Islam faith. The indigenous Berbers, who still have their own language and culture, make up about

Sierra Leone



Area 27,699 sq miles
(71,740 sq km)
Population 6 million
Capital Freetown
Currency Leone
Official language English
Life expectancy 42 years



The West African nation of Sierra Leone was set up by the British in 1787 for freed African slaves. In 2002, it emerged from a decade of civil wars, which displaced nearly two million people. Economic recovery, with the help of foreign aid, has been slow.



▲ DIAMONDS

Sierra Leone is rich in diamonds—a major revenue source for the country. However, much of its civil war was funded by the illegal trade of diamonds, known as “blood diamonds.”

Mali



Area 478,766 sq miles
(1,240,000 sq km)
Population 15.8 million
Capital Bamako
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 54 years



Mali is a landlocked country in the heart of West Africa. The Niger River flows through its central and southwestern regions. Mali became a multiparty democracy in 1992. However, a military coup overthrew the elected president in 2012, and nearly two-thirds of Mali's northern regions have been captured by Islamic extremists.



▲ OUR LADY OF PEACE BASILICA

The Basilica of Our Lady of Peace in Yamoussoukro is one of the largest churches in the world. Construction was completed in 1989.

24 percent of the population. The Berber language, Tamazight, was recognized as a national language in 2002. Algeria's economic mainstay is its energy exports to Europe.

► BERBER MUSIC

Accompanied by rhythmic drumbeats, Berber songs are an important feature of religious ceremonies, marriages, and festivals.

